

American airpower directed at North Vietnamese forces proved a decisive advantage that kept North Vietnamese operations in check. Conversely, American bombing in populated areas undermined efforts to win the support of the South Vietnamese people, driving families and even whole villages to support the Viet Cong. Ultimately, perhaps, the indiscriminate nature of violence designed to protect American soldiers made them less safe.

US air superiority ensured that not a single American soldier in South Vietnam was killed on the ground by enemy aircraft during the Vietnam War.



Danger zone

A First Air Cavalry Skycrane helicopter delivers ammunition and supplies to US Marines during the 77-day Siege of Khe Sanh, in February 1968. The aptly named Skycranes were also used to deliver heavy artillery.

» AFTER

US forces continued to police the skies over Vietnam even after Vietnamization.

ONGOING DEPENDENCE

The process of **Vietnamization**—turning the war over to South Vietnamese forces—facilitated American withdrawal from Vietnam. However, US airpower still played an important role. It prevented a rout during the ARVN's **Laotian incursion** in 1971, then blunted North Vietnam's **Easter Offensive** in 1972.